

# The 8th–12th Grade *College Planning Checklist*

Check things off one year at a time, so senior year isn't a scramble. Built for Florida families.

## 8th grade

and the summer  
after

- ☐ Ask which middle school courses earn high school credit (like Algebra 1 or a world language)
- ☐ Plan a 9th-grade schedule with the right level of challenge for your student
- ☐ Start a service-hour log: Bright Futures hours count during high school (ask your district whether the summer before 9th grade counts)
- ☐ Make one folder (paper or digital) for awards, report cards and certificates

## 9th grade

grades start to  
count

- ☐ Know that core-course grades count toward the Bright Futures GPA from day one
- ☐ Find out your school's service-hour form and turn hours in every year
- ☐ Plan for two years of the same world language before graduation
- ☐ Try a club, job, or activity your student actually enjoys
- ☐ Save copies of report cards and awards in the folder

## 10th grade

explore

- ☐ Take the PSAT 10 or another practice test if your school offers it
- ☐ Ask the counselor about dual enrollment, AP, IB or AICE options and eligibility
- ☐ Plan a summer that builds something: a job, volunteering, a program or a project
- ☐ Keep logging and turning in service hours

**11th grade**  
the big year

- ☐ Take the PSAT/NMSQT in October (the National Merit qualifier)
- ☐ Take the SAT, ACT or CLT in winter or spring, and leave room to retest
- ☐ Ask the counselor for a Bright Futures evaluation to see where your student stands
- ☐ Build a first college list: reach, target and likely schools
- ☐ Visit a few campuses (see our Campus Visit Kit)
- ☐ In spring, ask two teachers for recommendation letters for senior year
- ☐ Over the summer, brainstorm and draft the main essay

**12th grade**  
apply + pay for it

- ☐ Write down every school's deadlines and requirements (see our Senior Application Tracker)
- ☐ Complete self-reported academic records where required (like UF's STARS or the SSAR)
- ☐ Submit the FAFSA as soon as you can once it opens
- ☐ Submit the Florida Financial Aid Application (FFAA): it's how students apply for Bright Futures
- ☐ Apply for scholarships every month, not just in spring
- ☐ Compare financial aid offers side by side before choosing
- ☐ Finish service hours and requirements before graduation. The FFAA final deadline is Aug 31 after graduation

**Tip:** Put one 20-minute "college check-in" on the family calendar each month. Small steps beat a senior-year pile-up.